

The son of a poor Kentucky farmer, the young Lincoln struggled for an education while earning a living through manual labor and working in a dry goods store. When he was 21, his family moved to Illinois, where he studied with a local attorney and began his political career as a Whig. From 1834 to 1840, he served in the Illinois legislature. In 1842, aged 33, he married Mary Todd, the daughter of a wealthy Kentucky enslaver. Later that decade, he served briefly in the U.S. House of Representatives.

In the 1850s, Lincoln abandoned the decaying Whig Party to join the newly formed Republican Party, which opposed the extension of slavery to the West, and in 1858 he ran for the U.S. Senate against the Democrat Stephen A. Douglas. In seven debates with Douglas, Lincoln declared slavery immoral, although he denied the right to interfere with it in the South, where it was protected by the Constitution. He believed only that it should not be allowed to expand westward.

Lincoln lost the Senate race, but his debates with Douglas had garnered him a national reputation. At the Republican Convention in Chicago in May 1860, he won the presidential nomination on the third ballot. In the campaign, the Republicans rallied supporters with torchlight parades, barbecues, and picnics. In November, Lincoln carried all the Northern states except New Jersey in the popular vote and was elected president.

The effect of the election was dramatic. Lincoln's rejection of the expansion of slavery was unacceptable to radical Southern politicians, and in December South Carolina seceded from the Union. Lincoln denied the right of secession: to destroy the Union without a just cause was "simply a wicked exercise of physical power." He carefully prepared his inaugural address with the hope of keeping the upper South from joining the secessionists.